

Act One, In Depth

Six Characters in Search of an Author · Village Players, Lausanne · dir. Kiarash Jamshidi

Everyone seated · scripts and pencils · no staging tonight

We have already read the whole play twice — once completely flat, once far too big. **Tonight we do not read it again.** We take Act One apart: what every line is *doing*, where the laughs live and die, and how fast the act really goes — so August's staging has a spine to build on.

The evening, step by step

18:00 Welcome & the frame

Everyone seated. Say it plainly: *we have read the whole play twice — flat and over-the-top. Tonight we do not read it again. We take Act One apart: what each line is doing, where the laughs live and die, and how fast it really goes.*

18:10 Warm-up

A short seated voice and breath warm-up.

18:15 Name the units

Go through Act One's six parts. Whenever the room feels *something new starts here*, stop and agree a short title for that beat — “The knock,” “We want to live,” “The veil,” “The hundred francs.” Everyone pencils the titles into their script. An actor can't play “Act One” — they can play “The Veil.”

18:45 Action the spine

Teach it in three minutes: for every thought, one strong verb aimed at the other person — *I ___ you* (I charm you, I corner you, I warn you, I beg you). Then action four stretches only: the family's arrival (*We want to live*), the faint and the veil, the Father's Defence (where *I explain* becomes *I plead* becomes *I attack*), and the bargain. Write the verbs in pencil.

19:25 Break

Fifteen minutes. Rest the voice.

19:40 The Father's arc, close-up

Map his four stages — **control** → **injury** → **attack** → **horror** — onto exact lines. Where does control first crack? Where does attack begin? Where does horror flicker? The others say what they see from outside at each stage.

20:00 The laugh map

As a room, mark every script: ✓ **laugh here** (the Players, the Manager's dryness); ✗ **the laugh dies here** (the veil; “He calls it pity”); ⚠ **danger** (“Valentine” must land as a wound, not a number). Comedy is timing nine people share — decide it together.

20:20 Italian speed-run of Act One

The whole act, script in hand, *as fast as humanly possible* — no emotion, no pauses, cues picked up instantly

(about 15–18 minutes). No acting, no stopping, laugh and keep going. It welds the shape into the body, forces everyone to *listen* for their cue, and shows the act's true speed.

20:45

Close

Go-round: each actor, one sentence — “*In Act One, I am trying to _____.*” Homework: start getting Act One lines into your head — August opens with Act One. Confirm next: the whole play, one cued read.

The questions you ask

After the flat read of each part, put these to the characters who appear in it. Answers in one sentence, in character — then move on. No wrong answers; they are for the actor to discover, not to perform.

Part I — The Rehearsal

In it: The Manager, Player 1, Player 2, Player 3

The Manager

- *What kind of day are you having before they walk in?*
- *What do you really think of the play you're forced to rehearse?*
- *What would make tonight a good night for you?*

Player 1

- *What do you think you're owed in this company?*
- *What was the best role you ever played — and how long ago?*
- *What are you afraid the others see when they look at you?*

Player 2

- *What keeps you patient with all of them?*
- *What do you do here that nobody thanks you for?*
- *What would you rather be doing?*

Player 3

- *What are you still excited about?*
- *What do you want to learn from the older two?*
- *What don't you understand about this job yet?*

Part II — The Arrival

In it: The Father, The Step-Daughter, The Manager, the Players

The Father

- *What do you need them to believe?*
- *Which story do you most want told — and why now?*

The Manager

- *When do you stop wanting to throw them out?*
- *What first makes you curious instead of angry?*

The Step-Daughter

- *Why sing “Valentine” to a room of strangers?*

Part III — The Veil

In it: The Mother, The Father, The Step-Daughter

The Mother

- *What are you trying to stop from happening?*
- *Who are you most afraid for?*
- *Why can't you speak the way the others do?*

The Step-Daughter

- *What do you want them to see that the Father won't say?*
- *What has he done to you?*

Part IV — The Defence

In it: The Father, The Mother, The Step-Daughter, The Manager

The Father

- *What are you ashamed of that you'll talk around?*
- *When you look at the Step-Daughter, what do you feel?*

The Mother

- *What is the one sentence he can never talk you out of?*

The Step-Daughter

- *Why is being 'made pretty' worse than being ignored?*

Part V — The Hinge

In it: The Son, The Father, The Step-Daughter

The Son

- *Why don't you want to be here?*
- *What were you promised as a child that you never got?*
- *What would you do if you could just walk out?*

The Manager

- *What do you risk if you listen to them?*

Part VI — The Bargain

In it: The Father, The Manager, The Step-Daughter

The Father

- *What are you offering him — and what are you hiding?*
- *What can a stage give you that nothing else can?*
- *What happens to you if he says no?*

The Manager

- *What finally makes you say yes?*
- *What do you tell yourself to justify it?*
- *What are you already imagining the audience will think?*

The Step-Daughter

- *What are you afraid they'll make pretty?*
- *Which part of the story must they keep, no matter what?*
- *What do you want out of being watched?*

What each person should do tonight

You — the Director

Run the room; frame each segment. Read first, talk second: ask what they found before giving your reading. Keep the Father off the lecture and on the fight. Protect the laugh map. Do not over-talk — when talk stops earning its keep, move to the speed-run.

Assistant Director

Keep the master notes: every unit title agreed, every verb chosen, every “who is more real” decision. Watch for the tone drifting or energy dropping and flag it. Brief anyone who missed a night.

Stage Manager

Time the segments and keep the evening moving. Note the unit titles into the prompt book (pencil). Run the stopwatch on the Italian run and read stage directions aloud where needed.

The Father

This is your evening. The Defence is the act's centre. Action every thought — panic hidden under intelligence, never a lecture; the argument must escalate, not repeat. Find your four stages: control, injury, attack, horror. End like a man who has just proved the walls of his own cell — not like a man who has won.

The Step-Daughter

You are the engine and the moral centre. Action your cuts cold — evidence laid down, not anger screamed. Find the one or two moments the cleverness drops and the hurt shows. “Valentine” is a wound thrown as a provocation, never a number.

The Mother

You are scored around the object and the silence, not around tears. Keep the Child-bundle and the veil doing your listening for you. Your few lines are load-bearing — “But you drove me away” is the one sentence he can never talk you out of. Say less than you want to.

The Son

Your stillness is a presence, not a passivity. You refuse to be in the scene, and every line is a door closing. Save the one crack — “somebody must be guilty who did nothing” — so it costs something when it comes.

The Manager

Play a director first, not a device. You move from “throw them out” to “there may be a play here” — earn each step. You also hold the comedy: your dryness sets the laughs, and your patience running out sets the danger. The turn is “God help me, it tempts me.”

The Players (1 / 2 / 3)

You begin as bored professionals and recede to the wings as an audience — keep reacting, dry and delighted, so the comedy never leaves the room. Nervous, not punch-line. The joke dies the instant the Mother's grief lands; be the first to feel it.

One rule over all of it: read to discover, not to perform. Nothing anyone tries tonight is fixed — the performances are found later, on the floor, in August. When the talking stops helping, stop talking and run it.